

Is the centre cracking? What recent elections reveal about Germany's changing party landscape

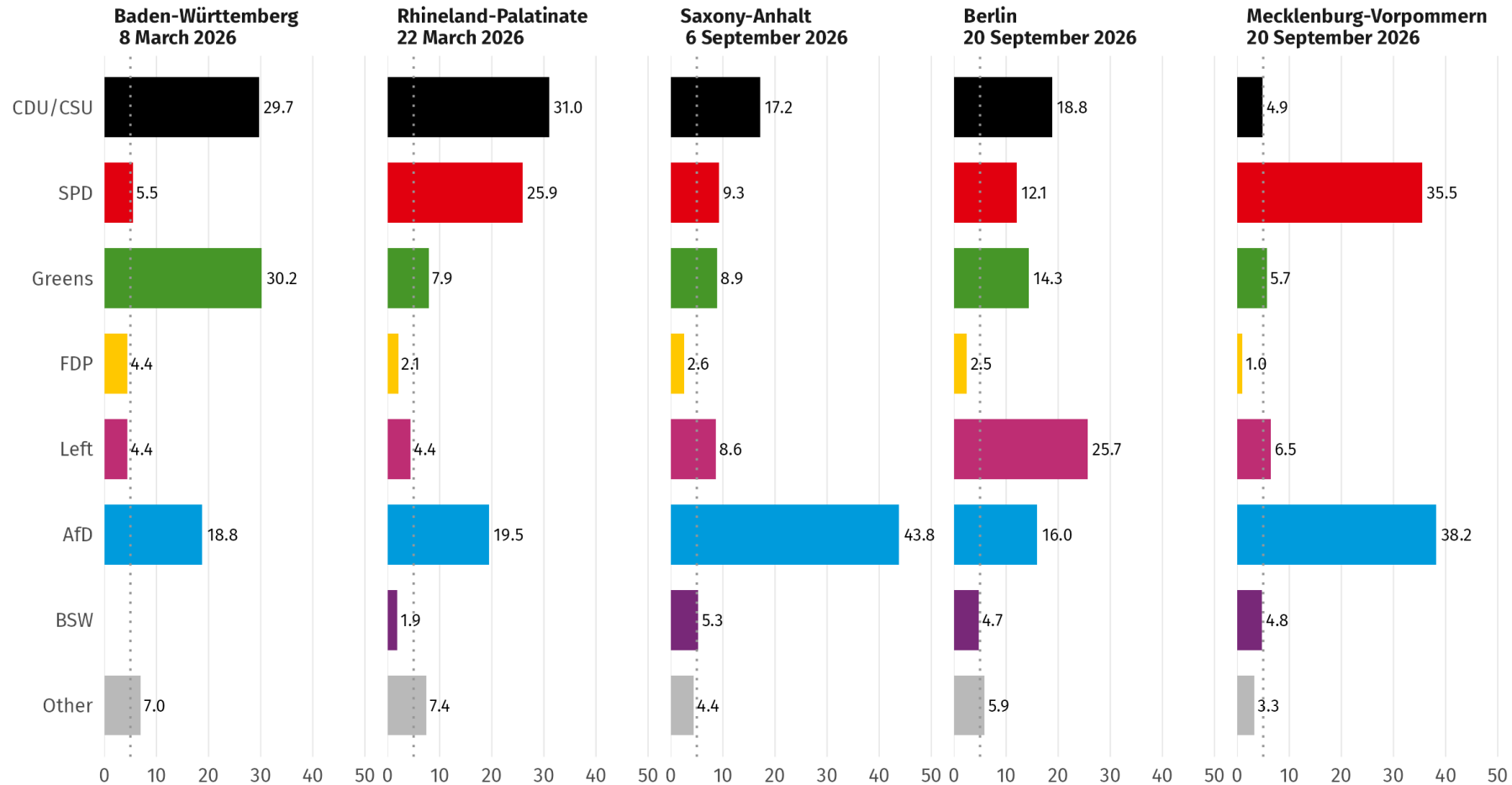
# **Four things open election data tell us about the 2026 state elections**

Simon Munzert • Data Science Lab • Hertie School, Berlin  
8 October 2026

# 2026: five state elections, four different winners

## Five state elections in 2026: five different outcomes

Vote shares in %. Dotted line: 5% threshold.



1

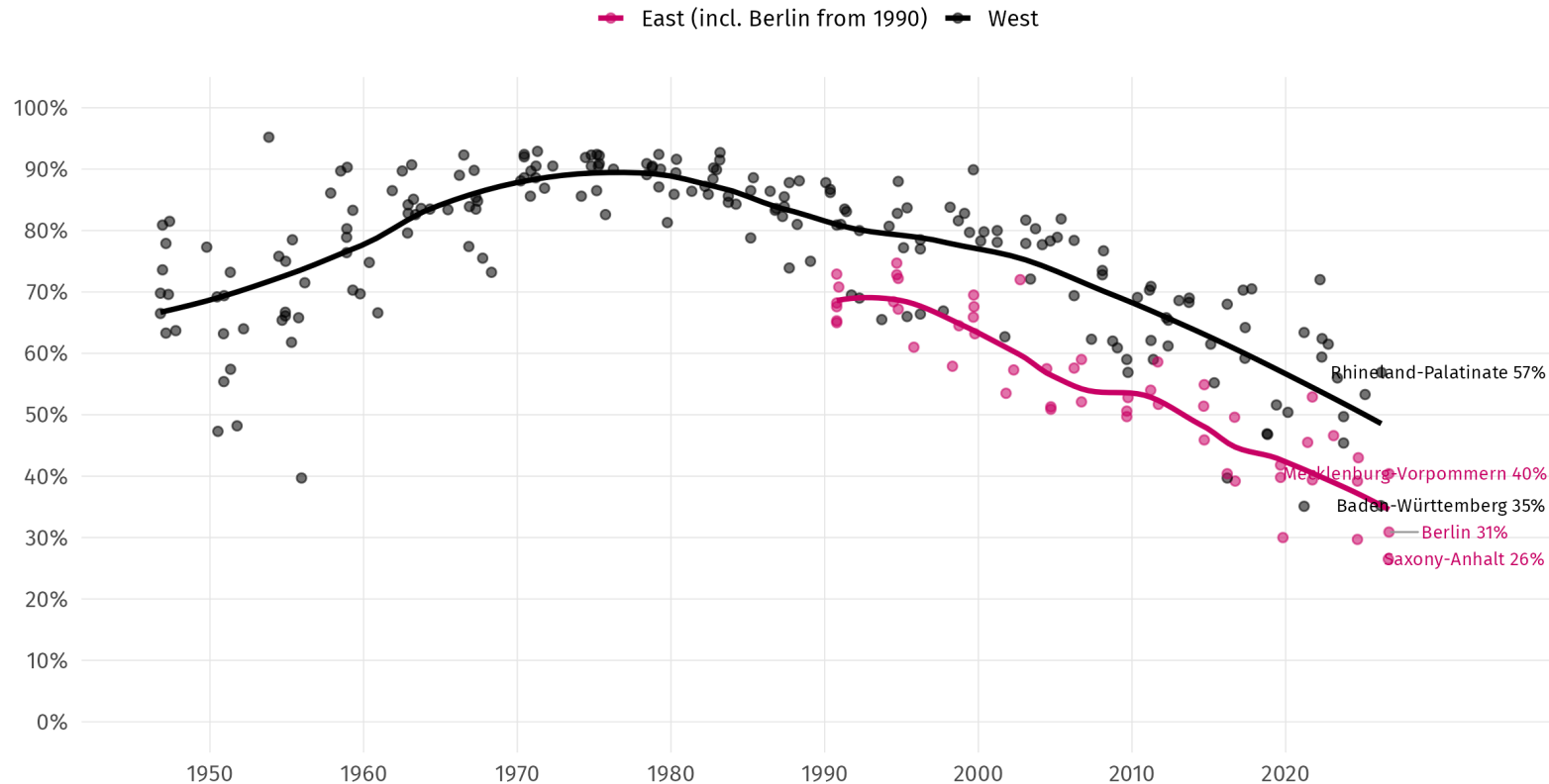
**The centre is not cracking.**

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# CDU/CSU and SPD have been losing ground since the 1980s

**The centre is not cracking. It has been eroding for 40 years.**

Combined vote share of CDU/CSU and SPD at every state election, 1946-2026



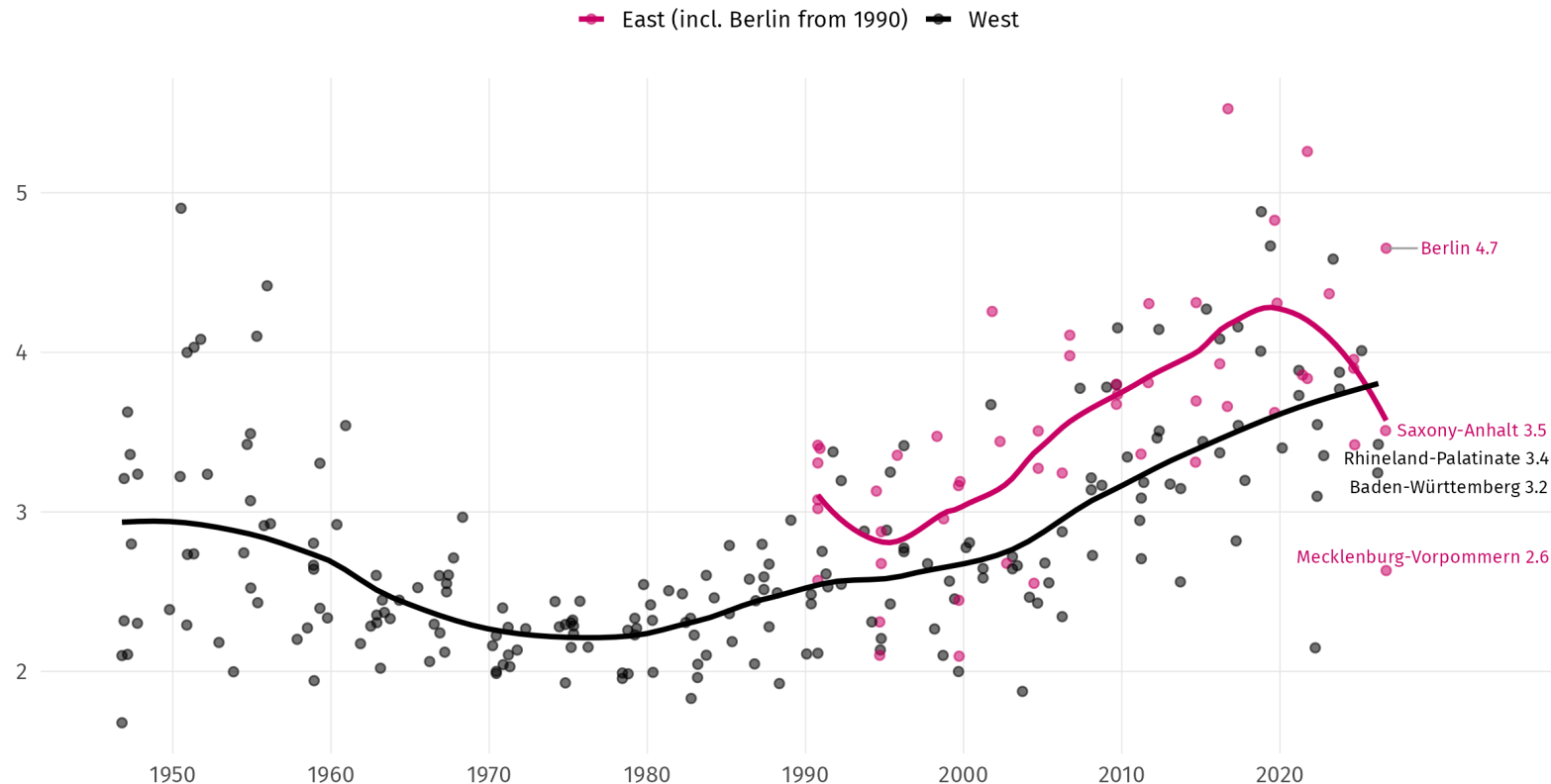
## Take-aways

- ➔ Combined share: West **89%** in the 1970s → **54%** in the 2020s
- ➔ East: **68%** in the 1990s → **39%** today
- ➔ 1955–2015: the largest party at **all 193** state elections was CDU/CSU or SPD. Since 2016: **8 of 38** went elsewhere

# State parliaments are more fragmented than ever

## State parliaments are more fragmented than ever

Effective number of parliamentary parties (Laakso-Taagepera, seat-based) at every state election



Effective number of parties (Laakso & Taagepera 1979)

$$N = \frac{1}{\sum_{i=1}^n s_i^2}$$

where  $s_i$  is party  $i$ 's share of seats

## Take-aways

- ➔ Around 2.2 in the West of the 1970s
- ➔ 3.5 to 4.7 in the parliaments elected in 2026
- ➔ But: shrinking as AfD becomes dominant in the East, FDP drops out

**2**

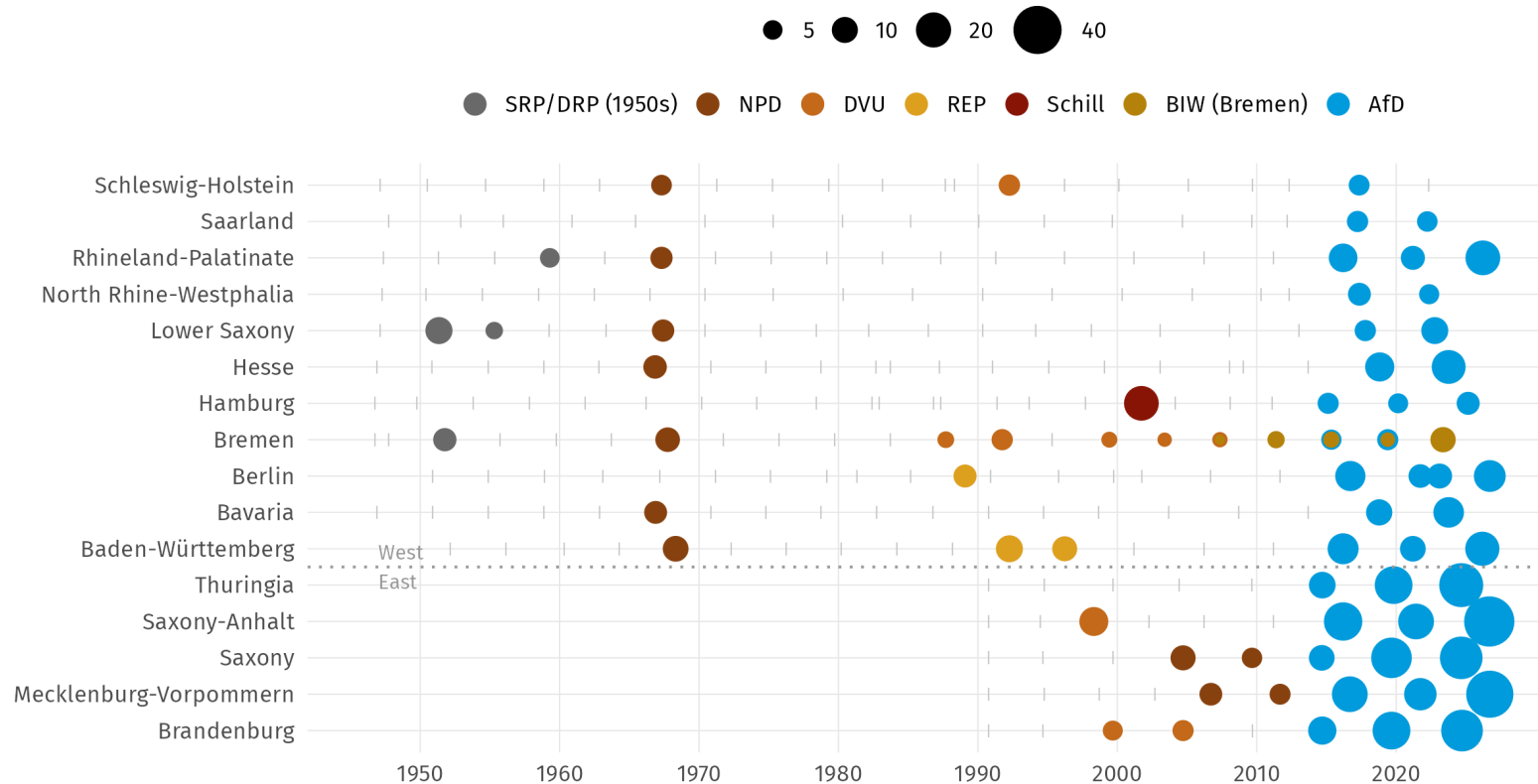
**The far right is not a new kid on the block.**

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# The far right in state parliaments is not new ...

## Far-right parties in German state parliaments, 1946-2026

Each dot = a far-right party winning seats at a state election. Grey ticks = all state elections.



## Take-aways

- ➔ NPD in **seven Landtage at once** in 1968-70
- ➔ DVU, REP and Schill in the 1990s and 2000s, mostly for a single term
- ➔ The AfD since 2014: **all 16** states

**3**

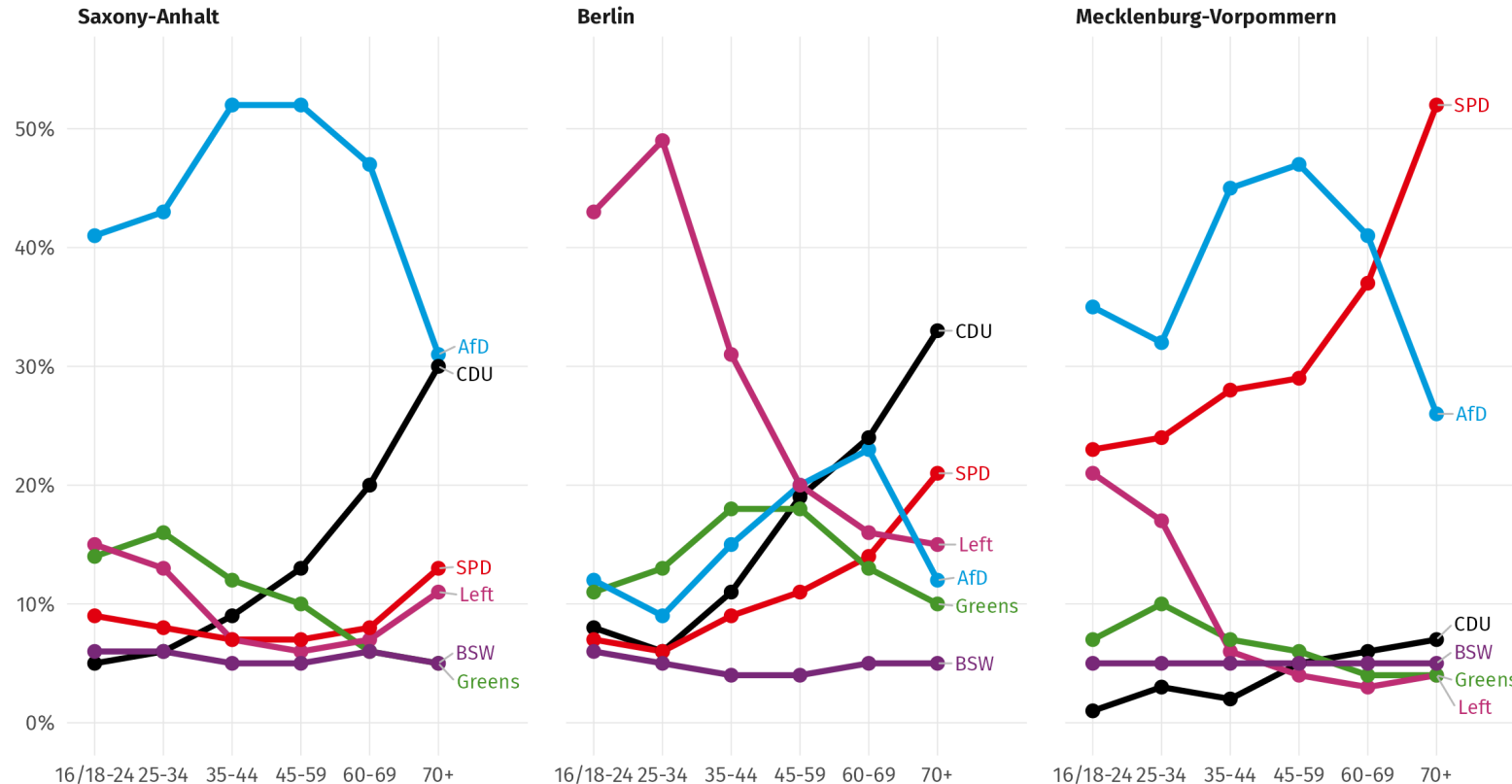
**Age, education, and geography are defining cleavages.**

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# Support for the centre is dying out

## Support for the centre is dying out

Vote share by age group, exit polls (infratest dimap / ARD). CDU and SPD peak among the over-70s, the AfD at 35 to 59.



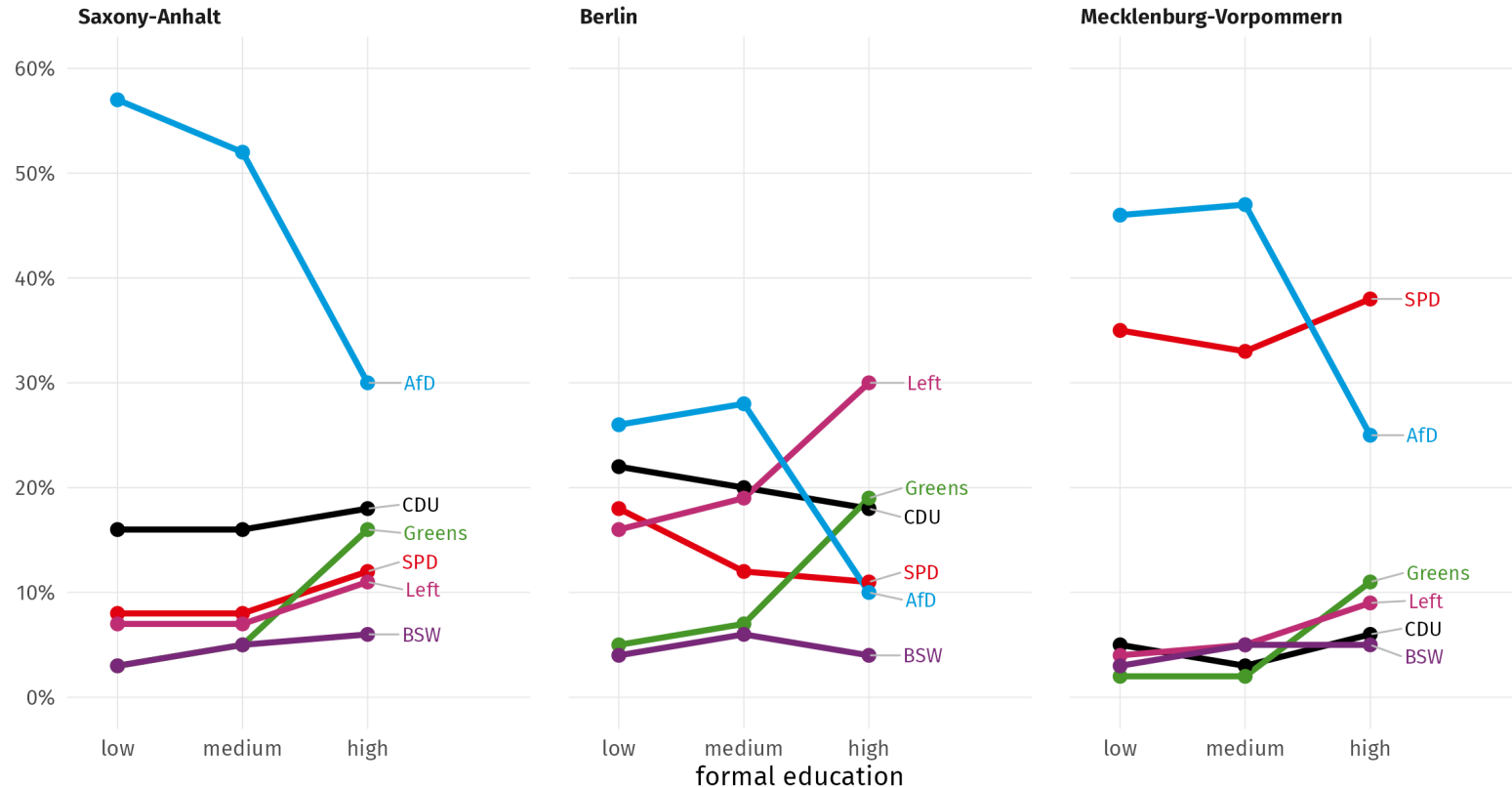
## Take-aways

- ➔ CDU under 25: **5%** in Saxony-Anhalt, **1%** in MV; the SPD's best group is the over-70s
- ➔ The AfD peaks at **35-59** everywhere and is weakest among the oldest
- ➔ Berlin under 35: **43-49%** Die Linke

# The AfD's steep education gradient

## Education divides less than age, except for the AfD

Vote share by formal education (low / medium / high), exit polls (infratest dimap / ARD)



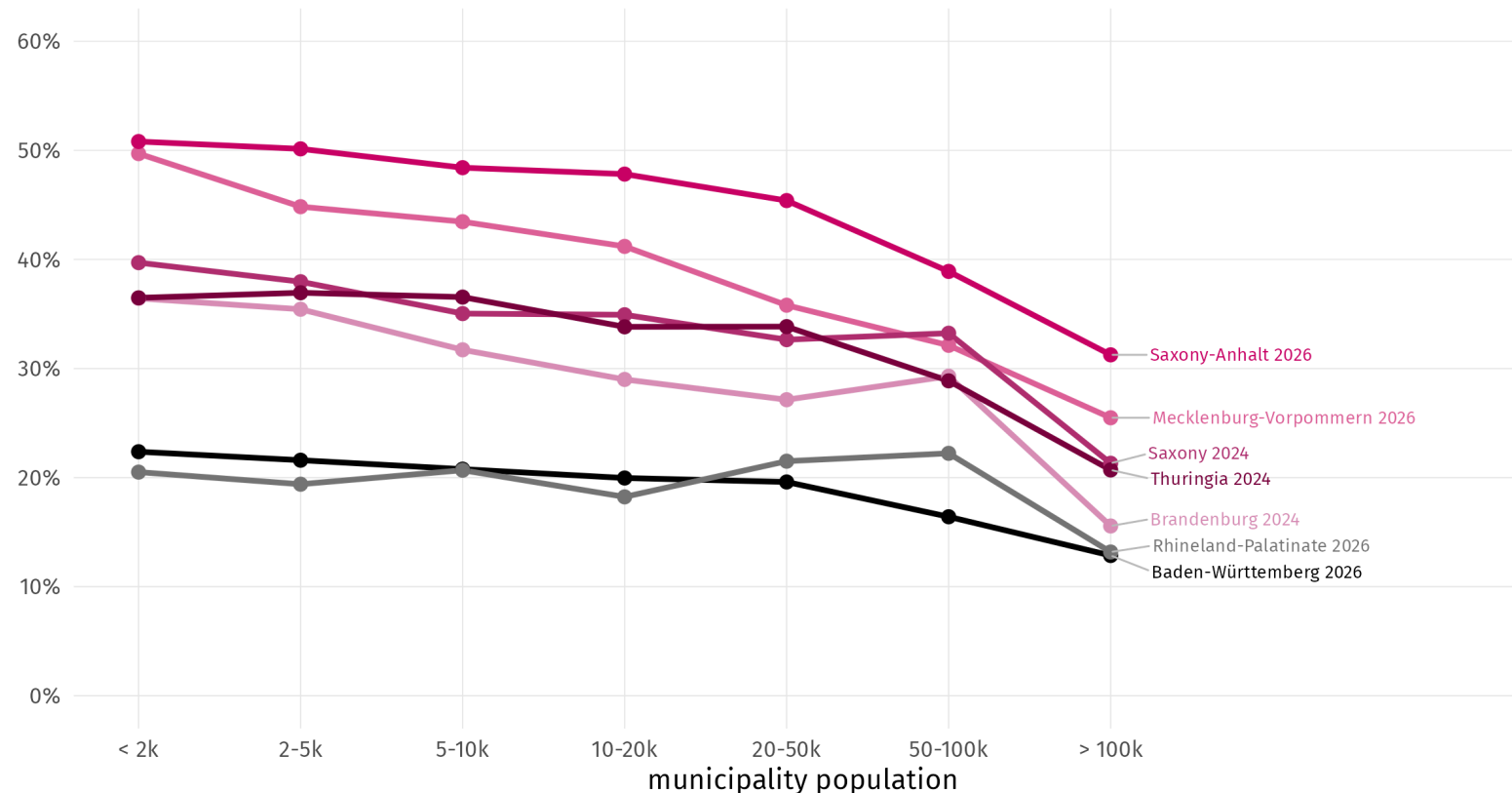
## Take-aways

- ➔ AfD by education (low / medium / high): **57 / 52 / 30** in Saxony-Anhalt, 46 / 47 / 25 in MV, 26 / 28 / 10 in Berlin
- ➔ The Linke and Greens run the other way

# Village vs. city: the AfD vote falls with municipality size

## Village vs. city: the AfD vote falls with municipality size everywhere

AfD vote share by municipality population (classes), eligible-voter weighted. East German states in pink, West in grey/l



## Take-aways

- ➔ Village-to-city gap: **16–24 points** in the East, **7–10** in the West
- ➔ Saxony-Anhalt: 51% in villages under 2,000, 31% in the big cities
- ➔ Only the AfD has this gradient; Greens and Linke are its mirror image

4

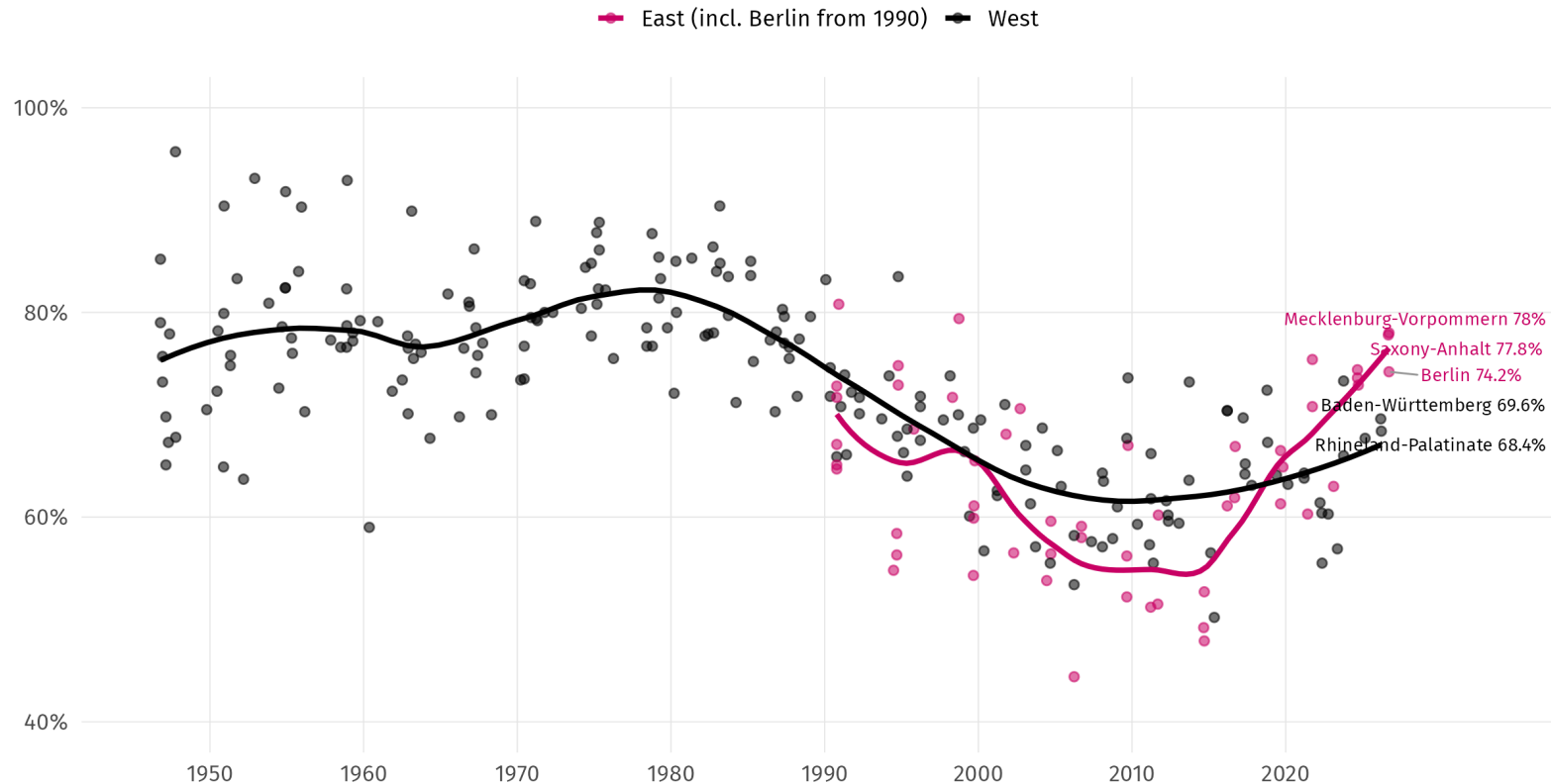
**Turnout is back.**

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# Turnout is back. The East now votes more than the West.

## Turnout is back. The East now votes more than the West.

Turnout at every state election, 1946-2026



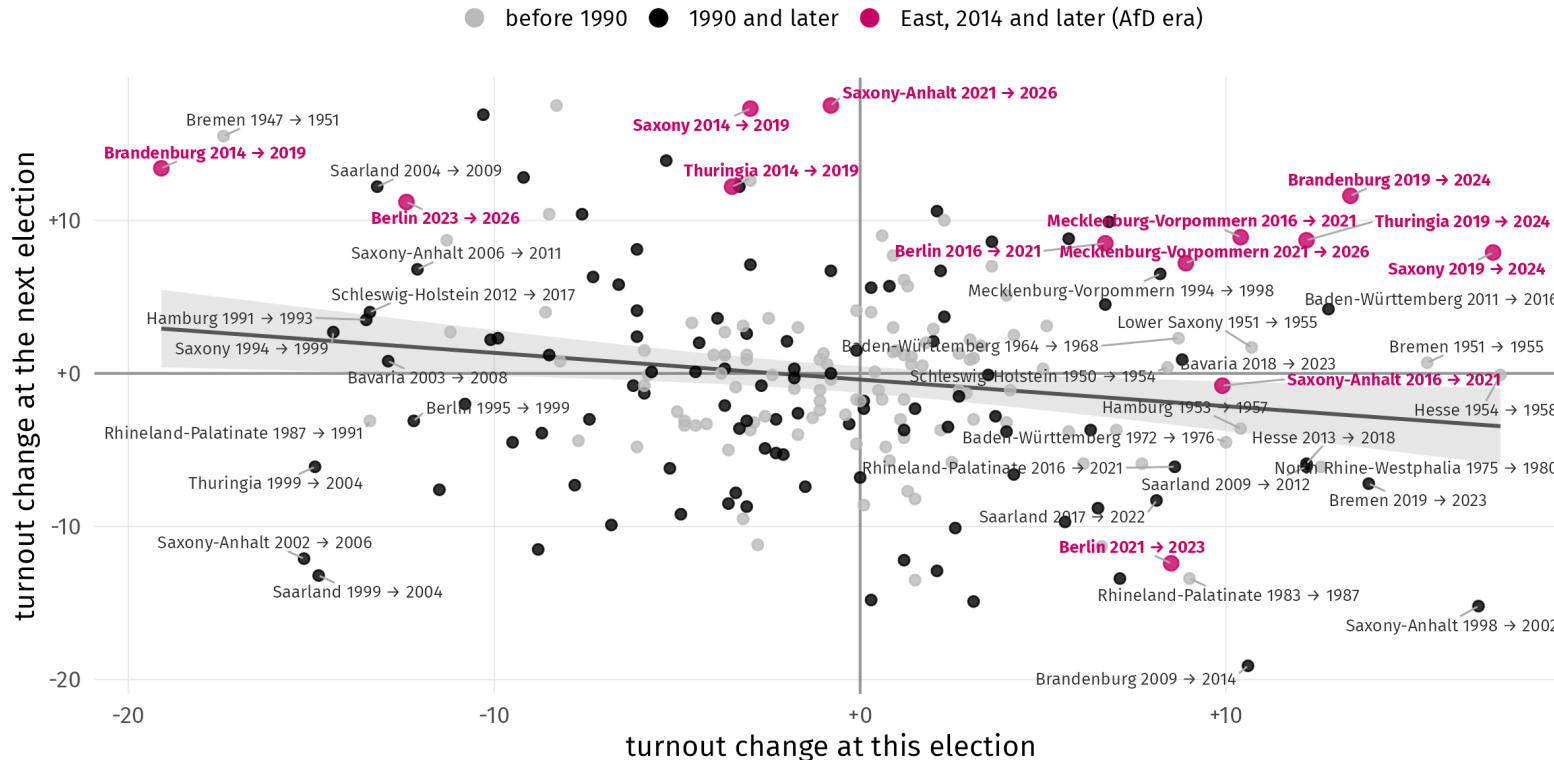
## Take-aways

- ➔ East German turnout fell to the low 50s in the 2000s and 2010s
- ➔ 2026: **78%** in MV and Saxony-Anhalt, 74% in Berlin
- ➔ Saxony-Anhalt: **+17.5** points, the largest increase at any state election since 1990

# ... and they are probably not going away any time soon

## Turnout surges partly revert, but mostly stick

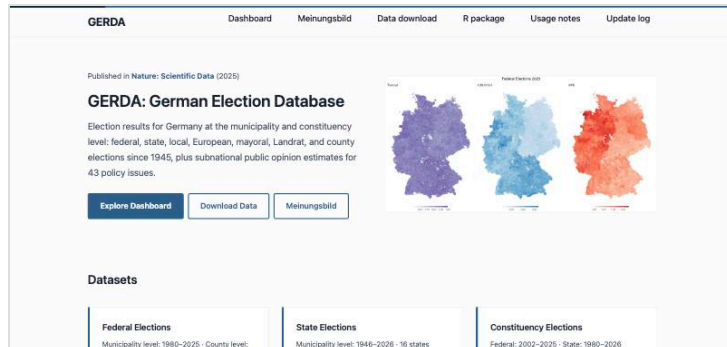
Turnout change at the next state election vs. change at this one (points), 226 election pairs since 1946.  
Regression slope -0.17: on average, about one sixth of a surge is given back at the next election.



## Take-aways

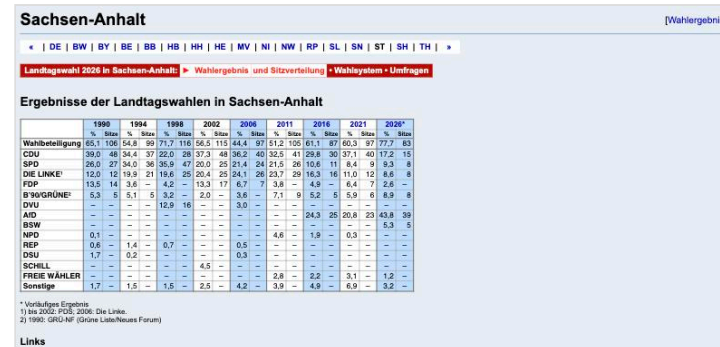
- ➔ 226 state-election pairs since 1946: only about **one sixth** of a turnout surge is given back next time
- ➔ Every East German surge since 2014 was followed by a **further rise**
- ➔ Voting is habit-forming: **+5 to +15** points next time, strongest for first-time voters

# Do your own research! The data are at your disposal



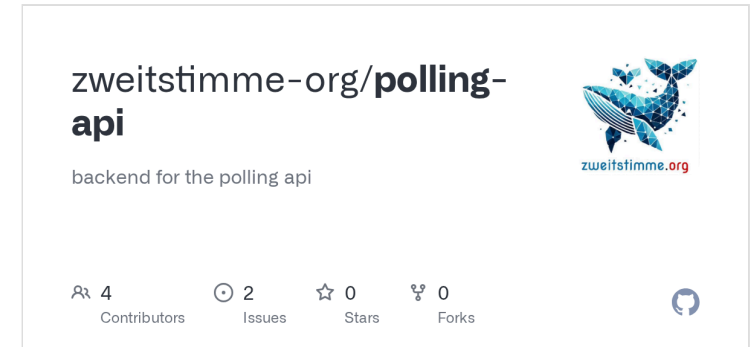
## GERDA

municipality- and constituency-level results 1946–2026,  
R package `gerda`



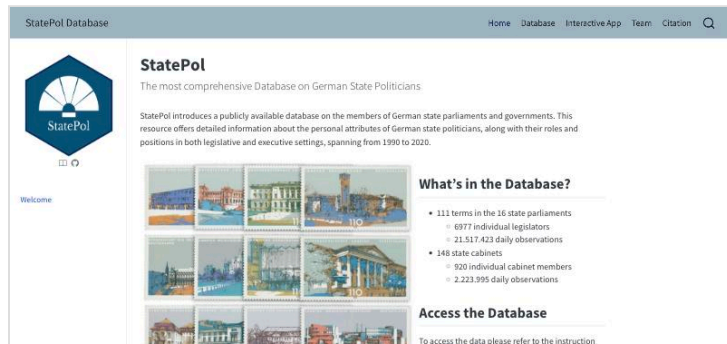
## wahlrecht.de

every state election since 1946, all parties, seats,  
turnout



## zweitstimme polling API

polls, forecasts and scenarios for federal and state  
elections



## StatePol

6,977 state legislators and 920 cabinet members, 1990–  
2020



## Bundeswahlleitung + Landeswahlleitungen

Repräsentative Wahlstatistik; precinct-level CSVs on  
election night



## GLES

panel and cross-section surveys for voter typologies  
and non-voter dynamics

*Slides, code and data*



[simonmunzert.com/state-elections-2026](https://simonmunzert.com/state-elections-2026)  
[github.com/simonmunzert/state-elections-2026](https://github.com/simonmunzert/state-elections-2026)